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Bishop's University addresses derogatory language allegations in internal memo

By Rachel Lau

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Bishop's University has reached out to its community about a tenured professor who has allegedly been using derogatory language in her classes.

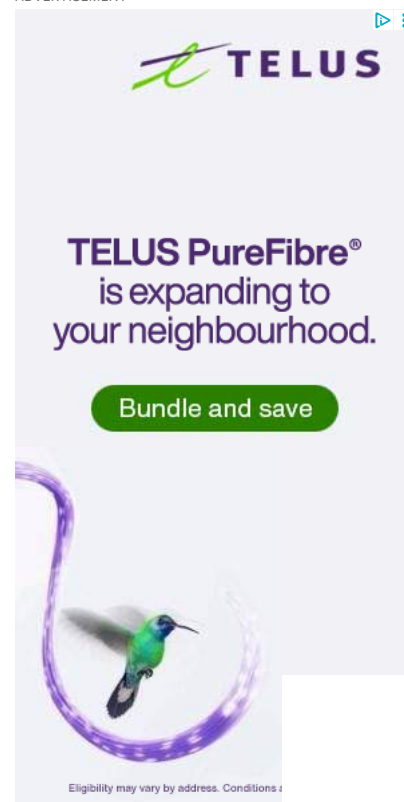
Bishop's University has reached out to its community [following a CTV News report](#) about a tenured professor who has allegedly been using derogatory language in her classroom for years.

In an internal memo sent to students and staff, and obtained by CTV News, the university's principal and vice-principals write, "We first want to recognize that many members of our community might find the content of the media report challenging and emotionally straining."

This comes after [allegations were made by multiple students](#) against sociology professor Dr. Cheryl Gosselin, claiming she stereotyped Black men and women and used triggering slurs when talking about the LGBTQIA2S+ community.

"She said the 'F' slur," sociology student Marie-May Lamothe told CTV News at the time. "When she said it, she said it many times. She said it at least six or seven times, and

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there was an audible gasp from the classroom."

In its letter, the university emphasizes that complaints "should be discussed with the professor, the program chair, the dean, or the ombudsperson. Reports or complaints will be treated confidentially and investigated fairly."



Students at Bishop's University allege a professor has been using derogatory language in her classroom for years.

All the same, Bishop's says it "will be pursuing a conversation in Senate, starting at its Jan. 24 meeting, on ways to better communicate resources and processes available to students."

It states that it "will also be examining how our processes can be improved."

The letter goes on to mention that "universities are places of learning through the free and open discussion of sometimes difficult or challenging subjects and ideas."

As such, "professors carry the responsibility to pursue truth, advance learning and disseminate knowledge in a responsible way. Open dialogue and constructive debate will always be encouraged, within a safe and respectful environment for all."

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In its memo, the university laments that its "internal processes are not sufficiently known or understood, or may be seen as insufficient."

However, political science student Aaliyah Wilburn told CTV News that she did ask Gosselin to consider the repercussions of using such strong language.

"She basically blew me off. Told me I was incorrect, and basically, she made me feel dumb for saying something," she said.

Wilburn says she also followed the necessary steps and reached out to the university's Equity, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI) department.

"It just felt like they were trying to find reasons and excuses for why Cheryl was saying the things that she was saying, when really there is no context that you need to have with it," she said. "There is no excuse that you need to have with it. Like, you said what you said; hold your teachers accountable."

Sociology student Malik Kessouagni says he witnessed Wilburn's attempts to open a discussion on the issue.

"Her [Gosselin's] defence was it's not a word that she uses on a daily basis," he said. "It's

Her [Gosselin's] defence was it's not a word that she uses on a daily basis," he said. "In my opinion, regardless of the fact if you use it on a daily basis or not, you still used it. Therefore, it's still an issue and you do not want to hold yourself accountable."

Following the CTV News report, Quebec's higher education ministry said it was shocked by the allegations.

"We are in close communication with the establishment, which confirms that it is doing everything in its power to get to the bottom of the situation," said a spokesperson for Minister Pascale Déry.

Responding to CTV News' request for comment, Bishop's University states, "the internal communication you are referring to reflects the fact that, as a learning institution, we are always open to reviewing existing processes to ensure better outcomes for members of our community."

The school also reiterated the fact that it "cannot comment on individual cases or ongoing processes."

Students taking Gosselin's winter 2025 semester classes tell CTV News that [following the report](#), their courses were reassigned to other professors.

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